The Truth About Dino Girl

By Barry Lyga

When I was a kid, I had a picture book about T. rex. There was an illustration of a bunch of them ganging up on a lizard. They weren't biting it or slashing at it or even *touching* it. They just surrounded the poor thing. And the lizard had...It had this look on its face. This long-suffering look of *Here we go again.* I knew how that lizard felt. And I hated that. [It] made me think that maybe...Maybe I was a lizard. I didn't *want* to be a lizard. I wanted to be a dinosaur.

Predator and prey. Prey and predator. Sigh.

INTRODUCTION

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There were certain things I knew for sure. I knew that the dinosaurs lived from 65 million to 230 million years ago. I knew that the theropods were the only dinosaurs to survive the entire Age of Dinosaurs--

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first on the scene, last to die off. I knew that they shook the earth when they walked.

I also knew that I was in love with Jamie Terravozza. He was a junior and on the baseball team, while I was a mere freshman, and a geek.

I remember the moment when I fell in love. One day Mrs. Knight asked us why animals never evolve with three limbs instead of four or two or six or eight. I raised my hand. I was the only one. I said, "Bilateral symmetry." Zik Lorenz chuckled and said, "What's this about bisexual?" Everyone laughed but me. And then I noticed Jamie. He wasn't laughing. He just rolled his eyes, flashed me a grin, then scribbled something on his notebook and slid it to the edge of his desk so that I could see it: IGNORE HIM. HE'S AN IDIOT. I loved him for that [and the] tattoo of a flaming baseball on his left arm. My bio notebook was filled with pages of me drawing that tattoo over and over again.

The problem, of course, was that he had a girlfriend: Andi Donnelly. A junior. Captain of the girls'

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soccer team. Drop-dead gorgeous in all the ways boys like.

SOOZ: Ugh, Don't you just *hate* her?

KATIE: No. I just want to be her.

And it was true. If I could be Andi, I would be the world's *greatest* Andi. She was perfect. And, of course, she had Jamie.

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In kindergarten, when they asked what we wanted to be when we grew up, I said paleontologist. [In] first grade, a boy accosted me on the playground while I was sitting off to one side, reading a dinosaur book.

BOY: You're not *really* a girl. Girls don't like dinosaurs.

KATIE: What do you mean? Of course I'm a girl. I'm wearing *pink*.

I pointed to my headband, just in case he didn't get it. Eighth grade--just last year-- I didn't care that the other girls were getting into makeup and boys. I didn't care that boys didn't think I was a girl. I didn't care about any of it. I just wanted a dinosaur nicknamed Katie [after me]. That was all I wanted.

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Until high school started. Until Jamie. Suddenly, I wanted something *else*. And I had no idea how to get it.

SOOZ: I don't get how you can *like* Andi. She's so mean. She once made so much fun of another girl that she went into the bathroom and cried for, like, an hour

KATIE: Jamie likes her, so there must be *something* to her, right?

I just couldn't find it in me to hate Andi. I figured it had to be difficult to be her. There were all kinds of stresses that came with being Andi, things I couldn't understand because I was *not* her. She was beautiful and funny and athletic and popular and I was... (shrug)

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[The next day] On the way to homeroom, I looked around me at the swarm of kids in the hallway. I felt so small in that moment. I was alone. And I felt like that lizard, the one being hounded by the young T. rexes. Just little lizard me, slithering along on my belly and along comes a bunch of big, bad dinosaurs and they're

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going to take their time to eat me. They're in no hurry. You know why? Because I'm just a little lizard. I'm nothing. Less than nothing.

Why couldn't I figure out the qualities in Andi that attracted Jamie? Why couldn't I mimic them, improve on them? I was smart. This was one more science problem, a biology test set in real life. Maybe that's crazy. But I couldn't help myself. I was desperate. But it didn't matter. Because one day it all became impossible.

That day was the worst day of my life. My own personal extinction-level event, right in the halls of high school.

I was leaving gym, following close to Andi. I did that whenever I could. Watching her. Listening. Trying to learn. Doing my research, like a good scientist. But then, suddenly, Andi turned around, as if she'd forgotten something. Maybe she had. I don't know. All I know is this: The worst thing that could possibly happen, happened. She bumped into me. Hard.

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I dropped everything I was holding. Including my bio notebook. Which landed spread open. The reproductions of Jamie's tattoo. That tattoo. Over and over and over again. I prayed that Andi wouldn't notice it. But her eyes dipped down.

Before she could say anything, I started babbling. I just couldn't stop myself. I was terrified and embarrassed and strangely giddy all at once.

KATIE: Please don't say anything. Andi. Please. Please. It's nothing. It doesn't mean...I would never try to take him away from you, really.

Her eyes got wide and then she laughed. She *laughed*.

ANDI: Are you *serious*? Do you think I'm afraid of *that*? He doesn't [care] about you. He needs you following him around like he needs a hole in his head.

KATIE: "Actually, um, that can be useful."

Oh my God! What on *earth*? Where was that coming from?

KATIE: The theropods had holes in their skulls to make their heads more lightweight.

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Shut up, Katie! I begged myself. *Shut up!* But I couldn't stop myself. I was on autopilot.

KATIE: It's something of an evolutionary advantage for a large predator to have at least one hole in its head, as a way of reducing drag when?--

ANDI: Hey!

Her eyes scrunched and her brows came together and her mouth twisted into a scowl. Andi was suddenly the one thing I never thought she could be--ugly. It shocked me into silence.

ANDI: Shut your little prissy, geeky mouth and listen to me, okay? Look, Dino Girl. There's, like, a natural order to things, okay? Girls like you do not get to go with guys like Jamie, okay? Especially when the guy is already with a girl like *me*. Did that get through your little lizard head?

Dinosaurs aren't lizards! I wanted to shout. But I said-- --nothing. I just stood there, pinned, frozen by her anger. I thought about that lizard in the picture book. Wouldn't it shock those T. rexes if it suddenly stood on up on its hind legs and roared and bit one of

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their heads off? Impossible, of course. A physiological impossibility. But I wasn't a lizard. I was a human being.

I managed to scoop up my stuff and make it to the girls' bathroom before I burst into tears. Why did she have to be so mean? Why? All I wanted was for a boy to like me. She was mean. Yes. But the worst part was that she was *honest*. Like she said, [Jamie] wouldn't like me. I was just a geeky girl who knew too much about dinosaurs.

She could have just walked away from me. That's the thing: She could have been *kind*. Why was she so mean? Just because she was a dinosaur? Just because *she* was a dinosaur and I was a lizard, predator and prey, and she *could*? She could. That's what it came down to: She could do whatever she wanted just because she was Andi Donnelly, and there was nothing I could do about it.

And then... It hit me. Like a comet. It *hit* me: The dinosaurs were more powerful, but the lizards *survived*. Look around. They still exist. They used to be prey, but they lived. Some of them are even predators now. It's scientifically, biologically impossible for a

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lizard to evolve into a dinosaur. But prey *can* become a predator. It happens all the time. All the time.

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SOOZ: Well, what are you going to do about her?

Sooz asked when I finally told her everything. I couldn't believe it when I heard the words come out of my mouth:

KATIE: "I'm going to destroy her."

Maybe it was insane to take on Andi. She was bigger than me. She was more popular, more important. But here's something every good paleontologist knows: Even the biggest die. Even the meanest get killed off by something that they can't see coming. Like a meteor. Or an insect. What it comes down to is this: In this world, you're either predator or you're prey.

I had to wait for soccer season. I had to wait for Andi to be in practice pretty much every day of the week. So I waited. And waited.

On one of my gym days, I "accidentally" left my math book in the locker room after changing. I begged

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Mom to take me back to school for it. We got there just as practice was ending. No one noticed my new little credit card-size camera. That's because I hid it in an empty blush compact, with a hole drilled through for the lens. So I could hold it up and look like I was just looking in the mirror, but I was actually snapping pictures.

Sooz took the best one and massaged it in Photoshop. I looked at the screen over her shoulder.

KATIE: It's perfect. It's *beyond* perfect.

SOOZ: (grinning) How many should we print out?

To have it all come out the next day would be too suspicious. *Someone* would remember me in the locker room. So I waited. Again, lying in ambush. I've already pegged the prey--it just doesn't know it yet.

After two weeks, I pounced.

Brookdale awakened to a new poster on its telephone poles and newspaper boxes and bulletin boards. The image Sooz had mocked up. Andi, half-naked from the shower in the locker room, drying her hip and leg, her torso completely revealed. Wet and gorgeous and totally unaware.

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Sooz gave it atmosphere and mood. She Photoshopped out the locker room and Photoshopped in a sleazy hotel room we'd found online. And at the top: CALL ANDI! with her phone number and her address. The first time I saw Andi that day, she was in tears. She was alone, rushing to the bathroom. It was the talk of the school.

I heard all sorts of rumors: It was an ex trying to get back at her. It wasn't really her. (Then why did it *look* like her? Why was her phone number on it?)

JAMIE: *If it's not real, how did they get a naked picture of you?*

What could she say to that? With the locker room Photoshopped out, how could she know *where* that picture had come from?

According to the grapevine, Andi had broken down into tears again at that. I wished, oh, I wished I had been there to see it!

I watched at lunch instead. I watched as Andi sat down at her table. Jamie didn't sit with her. In fact, *no one* sat with Andi.

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Sooz flashed me the biggest smile I've ever seen. I resisted the urge to high-five her. Too incriminating. But when I got up from the table, something amazing happened. The earth shook with my footsteps. It *shook*. From now on, the earth would tremble in my wake. And I knew. I knew what the dinosaurs sounded like.

They sounded like *me*....

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Barry Lyga
Book: Geektastic: Stories from the Nerd Herd
ISBN: 978-0316008105
Publisher: Little, Brown Books for Young Readers
Date (Month/Year): June 2010

AWARD HISTORY

2016 National Qualifier - MS

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